

Let's turn to the last assumption that the free will defense requires: the assumption that free will is a great good.

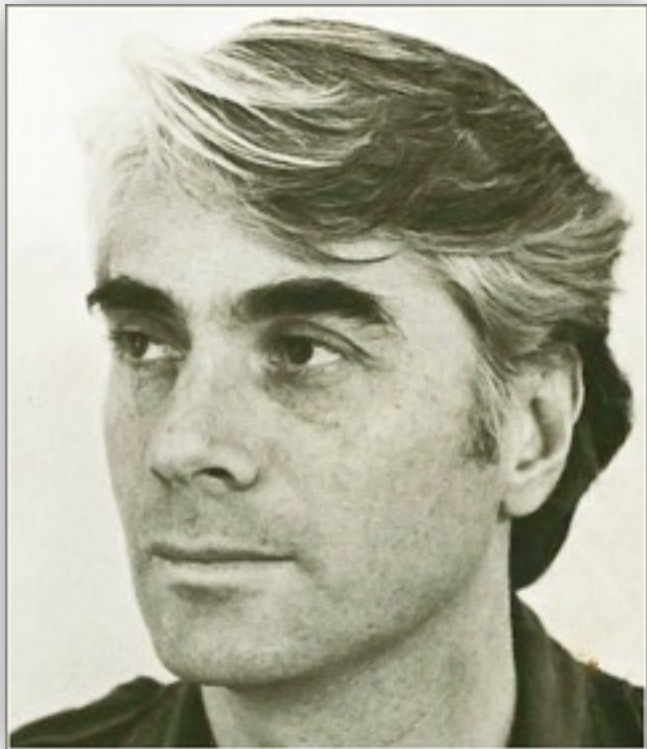
Free will is a
great good.

Even God could not
have given us free
will while ensuring
that we never used
that free will to
bring about evil.

We have free
will.

Many people think that it is; many think that life would not be worth living, or at least would be considerably worse, if we did not have free will.

The question we are raising is related to a famous thought experiment from the philosopher Robert Nozick.



“Suppose there were an experience machine that would give you any experience you desired. Superduper neuropsychologists could stimulate your brain so that you would think and feel you were writing a great novel, or making a friend, or reading an interesting book. All the time you would be floating in a tank, with electrodes attached to your brain ... Would you plug in? What else can matter to us, than how our lives feel from the inside?

Presumably the experience machine would also give you the illusion of free will. You would have the feeling that you were making decisions, accomplishing things on your own. (Of course, while you were in the experience machine you would not know that you were in the experience machine — that would ruin the illusion.)

If given the choice, would you plug in? (You needn't worry about your friends and family — they would have the opportunity to plug into their own machines.)

Nozick thought that, on consideration, people would choose

not to plug in:

“We learn that something matters to us in addition to experience by imagining an experience machine and then realizing we would not use it. ... Perhaps what we desire is to live ourselves, in contact with reality. (And this, machines cannot do for us.)”

Not everyone shares Nozick's view about this case. Here's another example to help bring out his point.

Naomi is married with children, and has many friends. She loves her spouse, children, and friends, and they love her too.

Susan is married with children, and has many friends. She loves her spouse, children, and friends. But they do not love her. Her spouse has been having an affair for many years, and her children resent her. Her friends complain about her to each other. But her spouse, children, and friends conceal this from Susan; they act toward Susan just as they would have if they genuinely loved her. Susan never finds out that this is just an act.

Does Naomi have a better life than Susan? Which would you choose? Many are inclined to favor Naomi's life.

But if that is right, then perhaps friendships and other loving relationships — and not just the illusions of friendships and loving relationships — matter to the value of your life.

If that is right, perhaps a similar thing should be said about free will. Your life being up to you — and not just the illusion of your life being up to you — matters to the value of your life.

That may explain the resistance that some feel to plugging in to the experience machine. If that is right, that lends some support to the idea that free will, and not just the feeling of free will, really is an important good.



replies to
Libet

A large, solid red circle is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the Libet experiments" is written in a white, sans-serif font, centered both horizontally and vertically.

the Libet
experiments



is free will
an important
good?

requires: the assumption that free will is a great good.

Let's turn to the last assumption that the free will defense







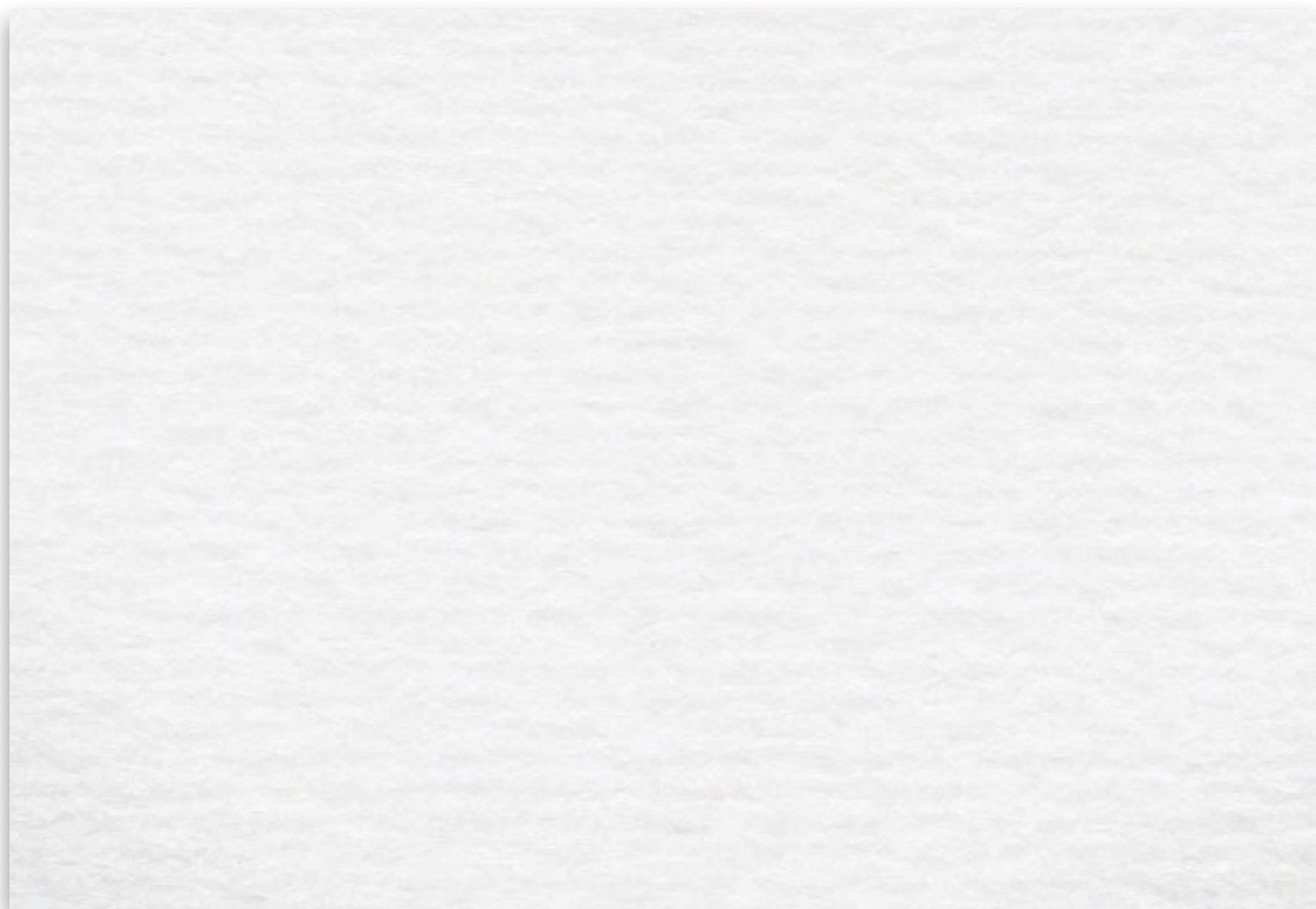
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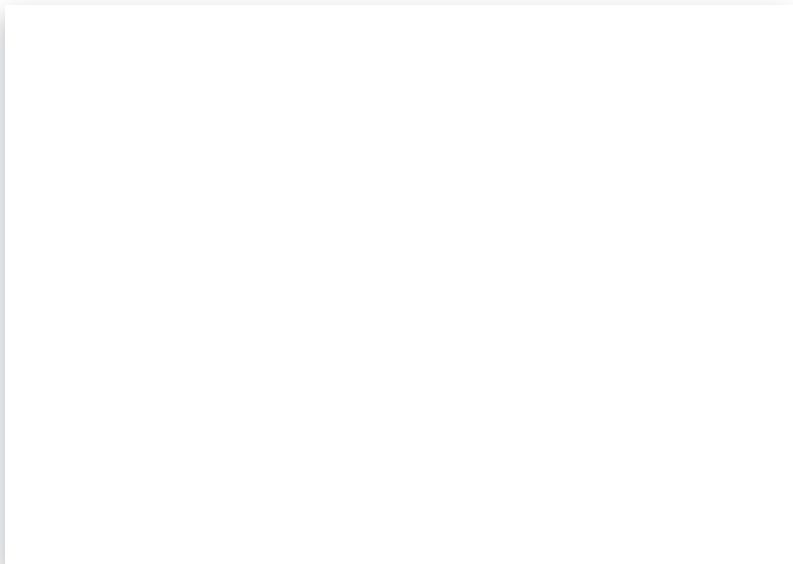
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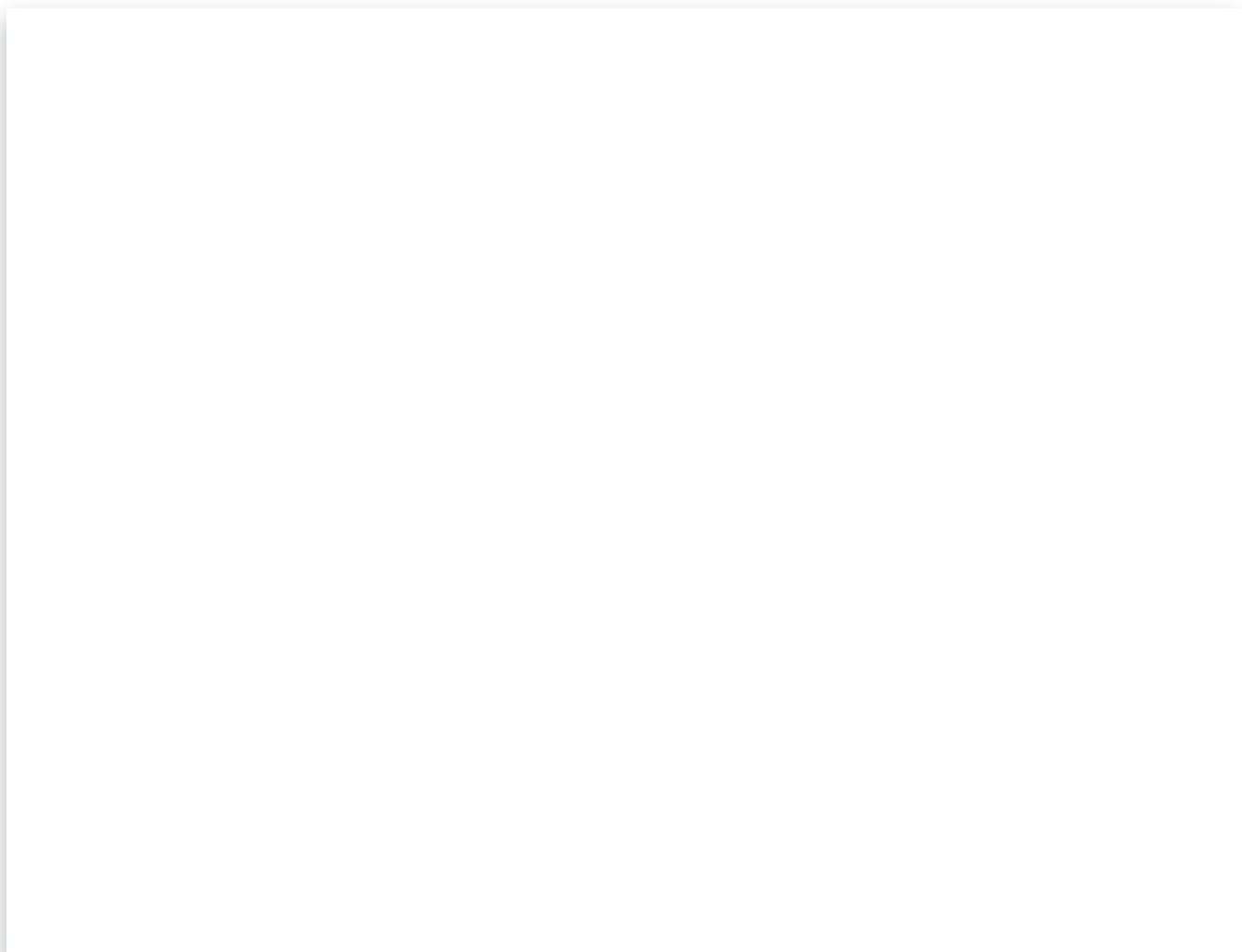
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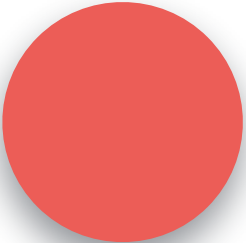


In ancient times, philosophers worried about the challenge to free will from fate. After

determinism. Our topic today is much more recent challenge to free

will prosper by contemporary neuroscience.

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